INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

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Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

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Published by:
mediastudies.press
414 W. Broad St.
Bethlehem, PA 18018, USA

Copy-editing: Emily Alexander

Cover design: Natascha Chtena

Landing page: mediastudies.press/iacmedia

Open Reader series - issn *(online)* 2770-940X | issn *(print)* 3143-4509

isbn 978-1-951399-33-7 *(print)* | isbn 978-1-951399-30-6 *(pdf)*

isbn 978-1-951399-32-0 *(epub)* | isbn 978-1-951399-31-3 *(html)*

doi 10.64629/3f8575cb.638fbdwo | lccn 2025938544

Edition 1 published in August 2026

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CHAPTER 41

Coming Out as Popular Media Practice: The Politics of Queer Youth Coming Out on YouTube

Sander De Ridder and Frederik Dhaenens

DiGeSt. Journal of Diversity and Gender Studies 6, no. 2 (2019): 43–60. https://doi.org/10.11116/digest.6.2.3.

Abstract

This contribution explores the popularity of coming out videos in contemporary media culture. Examining coming out videos as a collection of popular media practices, it demonstrates how media cultures are shaping and regulating the meanings of coming out videos in queer youth culture. The aim of this paper is to deconstruct the functionalistic logics in which society and academic insights are taken the emancipatory potentials of an online coming out for granted. This paper argues that the politics of coming out stories on YouTube should be seen in relation to how media authenticate value in the form of symbolic capital to coming out stories. It is shown how these values relate to sexual hierarchies; such popular media practices silence the emotional investment of queer teens necessary to acquire such symbolic capital. Thereby, media cultures attain a value (economic or symbolic) to queer youths' most vulnerable and defining moment.

Keywords

Queer Youth, Coming Out, Authenticity, YouTube, Popular Media Culture

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> *your support means the absolute world to me & i hope this doesn't change a thing. i love you guys & can't thank you enough for everything xx*
>
> YouTube celebrity ConnorFranta on his coming out video [1]

Preceded by a large number of queer youths, [2] popular YouTube stud ConnorFranta decided to record his own coming out story on his popular YouTube channel. He wanted to share his story to support other queer youth, and in doing so, he received an overwhelmingly positive response. The popularity of the video exploded rapidly, having been shared countless times across social media networks and reported on an international level by newspapers such as *The Guardian* (Parkinson, 2014). It seems that YouTube coming out videos, which may be seen as an opportunity for queer youth to come out of invisibility and receive support (Pullen, 2012), have rapidly expanded beyond their primary use within the queer community and became a popular mainstream genre on YouTube (Alexander & Losh, 2010). However, the popularity of coming out stories can be observed in mass media as well. The coming out genre has been adopted by celebrities, such as Olympic swimmer Tom Daley, while television talk shows, such as *Oprah*, are known for granting people the ability to disclose information about their intimate lives, including coming out stories. Some shows have been developed with the specific aim of helping youths come out to their parents, albeit on (live) television. For example, broadcasters in the Netherlands and the Dutch-speaking part of Belgium aired the reality TV show *Uit De Kast* (*Out of the Closet*), in which the host of the show emotionally guides a queer teen participant to come out to parents, family, and friends, while "live" on the air, in the presence of a television production crew (Boross & Reijnders, 2015).

The Internet and social media platforms have been applauded for the opportunities they offer to queer youths for a variety of different reasons, most notably in the process of coming out (Szulc & Dhoest, 2013). The Internet has been known to provide young queer teens with information about coming out. Additionally, social media offer queer teenagers the ability to participate in their own media representations and the opportunity for a kind of political activism wherein teens can share coming out stories to provide and gain support in queer communities, but also wherein queer youths can become more visible in mainstream culture (Wuest, 2014). Although coming out on social media can be therapeutic for individual storytellers, the current popularity of these coming out stories situates their personal and intimate narratives firmly within broader popular media cultures; coming out stories have become media spectacles—entertaining stories that are performed for "live" audiences by "ordinary" citizens as well as celebrities.

Our aim is to offer critical insights that investigate the conjunctions between queer youth culture and the culture of contemporary media, thereby deconstructing functionalistic insights that see digital media platforms as no more than meaningless intermediators. It is often argued—uncritically—that current participatory media cultures are offering queer youth digital platforms (such as YouTube) to allow emancipation (Wuest, 2014) and a political activism that successfully challenges normative gender and sexual identities (Alexander & Losh, 2010; Pullen 2012; Vivienne & Burgess, 2012). Examining coming out stories as popular

[1] See ConnorFranta (2014)

[2] Within the context of this chapter, the concept of "queer" will be used as an umbrella term for those who do not consider their sexual identity to be heterosexual, and who may identify as lesbian, gay, bisexual, or queer.

media practices, we challenge this idea of emancipation by reflecting on the politics of queer youth's coming out stories on YouTube. We consider the politics of these mediated coming out stories to be intertwined with the politics of sexuality.[3] Furthermore, we will relate these sexual politics to the way media cultures could be understood as shaping, but also regulating, the meanings of coming out stories in queer youth culture. Drawing on five YouTube coming out videos of gay male youths from the Dutch-speaking part of Belgium and the Netherlands, we will discuss the content of the videos as well as offering a grounded exploration of the comments from the audiences (Guest, MacQueen, & Namey, 2012), while also drawing on the context in which these video appeared to understand how they became popular. First, we will explore the role of coming out stories in queer youth culture and contemporary media culture. Second, we will analyze the particular subjectivities produced in YouTube coming out videos, and the process of 'making' them. Through these explorations, we will deconstruct a powerful myth related to coming out on YouTube—the myth that YouTube functions as a site of emancipation in queer youth culture. Third, we will reflect on the politics, arguing that coming out has particular symbolic and economic value authenticated by media, which is essential in understanding its popularity.

Coming Out Stories as Popular Media-Related Practices

A coming out moment, according to Susanne Driver, "is one of the main features of queer youth culture" (Driver 2008, p. 166). Although the act of coming out can be therapeutic for individuals, it is inherently a social process; a modern coming out story connects the private and personal spheres of an individual to the public and the political (Plummer, 1995, p. 82). Because of the perceived deviance of queer stories (Cohler & Hammack, 2007), a coming out story is, essentially, a political act, as it represents the movement of an individual out of a normal heterosexual subject position to something that is "Other." Since the 1960s, coming out stories have been an important aspect of gay and lesbian life. Through a collective coming out experience, a community has been established that has allowed for a sense of belonging to a group in which friendships and intimate and erotic experiences have been developed, and in which partners could be found (Weeks, Heaphy, & Donovan, 2001, p. 88). Previously, coming out stories had been "dramatically excluded"—symbolically annihilated, we could say—while in the 1980s, coming out stories were publicized as an empowerment strategy (Plummer, 1995, p. 27). Today, coming out stories support the construction of identity for queer youth, granting them agency on which to act in everyday life (Driver, 2008). These self-reflexive stories are said to stimulate progression by neutralizing stigma (Pullen, 2012); moreover, coming out stories have steered a wide "politicalisation of sexual difference" (Plummer, 1995, p. 89–90) that opened up the path for the democratization of diverse intimate sexualities in Western life-worlds (Giddens, 1992).

From a more critical sociological perspective or from a queer non-normative point of view, coming out stories are more complex, as they involve the cost of passing as heteronormative subjects (Smith & Watson, 2010). Coming out stories are considered being about conforming to a societal demand for coherent gender and sexual identities (Butler, 2006; Chambers & Carver, 2008), a demand that subjects people to making clear choices between fixed and

[3] The politics of sexuality concern the making and contesting of sexual hierarchies (Seidman 2010, p. 55).

essentialist identity categories. The identity work of coming out stories is "deeply paradoxical" (Weeks, 2007; 88), in that the need to create sexual identity narratives for empowerment narrows a whole range of queer experiences. For queer youth who do not want to inscribe themselves into the heteronormative sexual and gender order, the work of coming out can intensify the sense of insecurity if there is any uncertainty about how to label their sexuality (Driver, 2008). Rather than allowing queer teens the capacity to disclose their sexual identities, coming out stories are often discursively framed as "brave" acts of assimilation to a coherent gender and sexual order that allows a functioning in heteronormative society (Hackford-Peer, 2010). These narratives of assimilation have been adopted by gay civil rights movements; however, they have been proven to be problematic for those youths who do not conform to normative gender norms, such as the effeminate boy or the masculine girl (Driver, 2008). Eminent scholar on sexuality Jeffrey Weeks, referencing Judith Butler's (2006) *Gender Trouble*, argues that these stories are no more than stylized repetitions of performative acts, indicating that coming out stories are no more than "fictions" structured through the repetitive use of a particular language (Weeks, 2007, p. 88). While coming out stories may be important for queer youths in everyday life on an individual and social level, the deeply paradoxical nature of coming out stories should make us aware that they only become meaningful in larger heteronormative societies and cultures.

Contributions to the study of queer youth culture have focused on digital media as opportunity structures in which one can participate in empowering storytelling that gives meanings to a diversity of gender and sexual identities to (possibly) large audiences (Wuest, 2014). Other studies have been critical of the democratic value of this storytelling (Sender, 2012; Cover & Prosser, 2013, Alexander & Losh, 2010)—we will discuss these studies further in this article. Although these two perspectives might seem to be in opposition, their views regarding the role of the media within the politics of telling stories about gender and sexual identities seem to be in agreement. Both these perspectives explore the deeply paradoxical nature of everyday life stories on gender and sexual identities (as we have explained in our discussion of coming out stories), though they both reduce the role of storytelling platforms, such as YouTube, to meaningless intermediators (De Ridder, 2015; van Dijck, 2012). However, deeming the role of the media to be meaningless is problematic when investigating the conjunctions between queer youth culture and contemporary media culture. We argue that "the media" must be viewed as a meaningful mediator that centralizes symbolic power.

"The media," as we will use the term, does not refer to a particular media institution (as, in our case, YouTube) or to a particular media text, but rather, is used as a way to make sense of societal and cultural practices related to the media (Couldry, 2012); specifically, we consider how coming out stories, which were not media-related before, become meaningful as popular media-related practices. By "popular," we mean that they are popular in a quantitative sense (e.g., "coming out" generates more than 12,800,000 results on YouTube), and also in a qualitative sense, in that these deeply personal stories have become an entertaining genre that features a recognizable narrative (Alexander & Losh, 2010; Cover & Prosser, 2013). This genre has become significant in media culture and does not limit itself to YouTube; it is also well-known to include moments of "live" emotional confessions in television talk shows, such as Oprah (Oprah.com, 2013), or in the aforementioned reality TV show Uit De Kast (Boross and Reijnders, 2015).

Sexual Subjectivities and YouTube Coming Out Videos

Queer youth culture has benefitted from the Internet in many ways. Not surprisingly, the Internet has been considered a "lifesaver" for many queer teens (Gross, 2007). This has been demonstrated in the work of Mary L. Gray (2009) who argues that the Internet offers queer rural youth the opportunity to transcend their everyday life spaces to come "out of invisibility" in ways that would not otherwise be possible. Moreover, the moment of coming out is known to structure Internet use of queer youth; specifically, it has been shown that the use of the Internet for "sexual identity formation" (e.g., to seek contact with other lesbian, gay, and bisexual people or to look for information) is significantly higher in the period before coming out (Szulc & Dhoest, 2013). Bryan Wuest's (2014) essay "Coming Out Videos and Queer Identities on YouTube" supports this view by presenting the example of a 19-year-old gay boy who, in an online interview, declared that YouTube "opened up a world" for him in times when he felt alone without any contact with gay peers (Wuest, 2014, p.23). Such insights show that for queer youths, with regard to their social lives, the role of the Internet must not be taken lightly, but should be seen as playing a key role in the young person's rite of passage in terms of gender and sexual identity development. For Wuest, YouTube coming out stories function as texts that are used to achieve acculturation and visibility. Acculturation refers to the notion of "queer youth receiving information about a shared culture and experience in order to better equip themselves to both interact within the queer community and to survive in mainstream culture," while "visibility" refers to the idea of "viewers seeing varied representations of queerness, and vloggers deliberately making themselves visible and 'real'" (2014, p. 24).

While Wuest's arguments focus on the function of coming out videos on YouTube as producing empowered sexual subjectivities by supporting acculturation and visibility, others have argued that these videos could reproduce normative subjectivities, rather than reflect a wide range of queer experiences in youth culture. Jonathan Alexander and Elisabeth Losh (2010) argue that coming out stories on YouTube "may still be subjected to architectures of corporate control that can contain and filter out certain queer experiences" (2010, p. 48). Rob Cover and Rosslyn Foster focus on the memorial accounts in coming out stories on YouTube, stating "The memorial accounts in coming out stories, whether in older texts and face-to-face groups or across new sites such as YouTube, indicate the persistence of stereotypes as a narrative form deployed for the coherence of sexual subjectivity" (2013, p. 92). Cover and Foster argue that in the narrative structure of coming out videos, a linear trajectory from the past to the future is established. Such a linear trajectory argues how the storyteller always knew he was gay: "I always knew I was gay from early childhood" (2013, p. 86). The authors argue that these memorial accounts, or "acts of re-remembering," are constructed out of a cultural demand for coherent, stable, and fixed gender and sexual identities, and that they should be seen as normative and stereotypical interpretations of memories, rather than based on "true facts." This stabilization of queer identities in the YouTube coming out videos through the act of re-remembering is viewed as the standardized genre for coming out narratives online, constituting a performative queer identity that reinforces clear normative conventions and coherence.

Exploring YouTube Coming Out Videos

We have explored five coming out videos on YouTube as shown in table one. We will describe the story they have to tell, but also show fragments resulting from a grounded analyses of the comments responding to the YouTube coming out videos. Of each video, we analysed 100 comments (the first 50 and last 50 comments on each video). Our cases are posted by gay youth from the Netherlands and the Dutch-speaking part of Belgium. [4] Focusing on videos from the relatively small Dutch-speaking language community, allows us to show how coming out stories, as a genre, travelled outside of the Anglophone language context that is usually dominantly reported upon. Furthermore, we will elaborate on the societal debates surrounding these YouTube videos. Rather than taking a representative sample of Dutch-speaking YouTube coming out videos, we have chosen to elaborate in-depth on five topical cases to demonstrate our theoretical arguments.

Table 1: Overview of the five cases

Youtube channel title	**Title of the video**	**Date uploaded**	**Number of views**	**Number of comments**	**Likes / dislikes**
Broer.	*Coming-out Jeltje | Broer*	8 May 2015	14.099	113	580 likes/16 dislikes
EricosVlogs	*Mijn Coming Out Verhaal*	12 October 2010	70.046	519	1103 likes/65 dislikes
Furtjuh	*Mijn Coming Out Verhaal | #Furtjuh*	10 December 2015	594.460	26.333	44244 likes/1042 dislikes
Hjalmar	*MIJN COMING OUT—Hjalmar*	29 June 2015	22.537	237	682 likes/26 dislikes
Luka Peeters	*Coming Out*	12 December 2014	167.698	252	1682 likes/90 dislikes

The coming out stories included in our sample all have some common textual elements that are typical for the genre, such as the use of a talking head (a narrator viewed in a close-up talking in the camera lens as used in vlogging), while the background is usually a bedroom. While *Luka Peeters* filmed the video in black and white, which gave the video a more emotional appeal, the other videos used bright and colorful lightening. *Hjalmar*, for example, included a rainbow flag in the editing to introduce the video, which faded away once he started talking. *Hjalmar's* use of the rainbow flag symbol underscores the video's political goal; all of the included examples were very much about empowering other gay youths and minorities. All of the stories had more or less the same structure, each of them was ending with the most important message they wanted to share: [5]

> We should stop judging people based on their sexual identity (Broer.)

[4] We consider all the narrators included in the five case studies as youth. Although we do not know the exact ages of the narrators, *Broer., Hjalmar and Luka Peeter*s are teenagers older than 16, while *EricosVlogs* and *Furtjuh* are in their twenties.

[5] We translated all of the examples (the texts from the YouTube coming out videos, comments on the YouTube videos and extracts from newspaper articles) we include here from Dutch to English for practical reasons. We have been very careful not to change the intended meaning.

> You are who you are and people should respect you (EricosVlogs)
>
> Be yourself and become the best version of yourself (Furtjuh)
>
> Be yourself (Hjalmar)
>
> You are who you are and people should respect you (Luka Peeters)

These political acts of empowerment are not only limited to the video either but are also found in the comments responding to the videos. The comments section often reinforces the supportive goal of the video, with commenters sharing their own experiences of coming out and numerous affirmative reactions that show respect, pride, courage, and gratitude for the sharing. In this way, YouTube coming out videos were contextualized as brave acts that can help other people through the process of sharing their own stories, allowing queer youth to cope with the rejection and trauma of everyday life:

> When I found out I was gay I was terrified and did not dare to tell it to anyone. […] I told my friends but one of them told it to everyone else at school. I'm still bullied now, but not by my friends. (commentary on the video of Hjalmar).

The coming out stories in the videos had a clear symbolic formula, which means there was a recognizable narrative in which the storyteller constructs a linear progression towards an essential gay identity, starting from the position of a confused sexual subject. This creates, as mentioned by Cover and Prosser (2013), a performative identity that is based on repetitive communicative acts. For example, *EricosVlogs, Furtjuh* and *Hjalmar* start their coming out story at the moment when they are 14 or 15 years of age. Such a consistent narrative construction of a gay identity is essential to a video's political identity project and is attached to the act of re-remembering what it was like to realize they were gay. The videos of *Luka Peeters* and *Broer.* are somewhat different. *Luka Peeters'* video is an actual coming out moment, in which he addresses himself to the many friends and acquaintances that did not know he was gay yet; "I want everyone to know, this is the reason I'm making this video". The YouTube video of Broer. has an interesting twist; the video shows a boy coming out as straight, while relying on the same storytelling conventions as those of the typical genre of gay coming out videos. *Broer.* is a YouTube channel run by two teenage Dutch boys calling themselves "best friends". One of them identifies as gay, while the other is straight. Showing the straight boy coming out instead of the gay one, the video exposes coming out discourses as fictions.[6] The video explains how coming out as gay makes no sense, as it is based on a system of inequality. Broer. illustrates the coming out genre's potential for resistance by questioning the idea of assimilation; gay youth are expected to be 'brave' and therefore expose their sexual identities. The comment section attached to the YouTube video of Broer. opened up as a space for critical reflection on the idea of 'coming out':

> I think it is ridiculous that you still need to come out of the closet. This means people are still not equal. Good you are showing this in the video! (commentary on the video of Broer.)

While all of the included videos were clearly political and aimed at helping other gay peers, for some of those young people that were telling the story on YouTube, it demanded a considerable emotional investment to do so. This was illustrated in the video of *Luka Peeters* in which he

[6] Other videos on the YouTube channel of *Broer*. make clear one of the friends is gay, while the other is straight.

clearly showed his emotional discomfort, talking with a slow and almost whispering voice. At the beginning of the video he claimed: "I have never been so nervous in my life". *Furtjuh* started the video with reading the many cruel and homophobic comments he received on his Instagram posts that include a picture of him and his boyfriend. While he continuous talking about the many difficulties he experienced when he needed to come out as gay (dealing with bullying and feeling excluded), he starts crying.

Further, while it is shown in table one that the coming out videos are much more liked than disliked, there are a considerable number of commenters rejecting the coming out videos. Some comments respond to coming out videos in a way that privileges heterosexuality or use homophobic language (McCormack, 2012); these comments contribute to the meaning-making of coming out as on the YouTube platform. Moreover, they illustrate how the emotional discomfort of the storytellers is real, they are aware they will need to deal with negative comments. As *Furtjuh* states at the end of his video: "I know that, probably, when you see this, you will find haters in the comment section saying nasty things". Also, the emotional investment is recognized on YouTube, as one commenter on the video of *Hjalmar* states: "It is so brave that you dare to share this on YouTube, I would be too afraid". We observed that religious positions and convictions were used to reject the coming out story. More direct homophobic language, on the other hand, is aimed at ridiculing the coming out video. Often such homophobic comments were examples of anonymous trolling.

> Gays are just not normal, just read the Bible (commentary on the video of Hjalmar)
>
> You nasty gay, just go away (commentary on the video of EricosVlogs)
>
> You had better stayed in the closed and locked yourself up, hahaha (commentary on the video of Luka Peeters)
>
> I really don't like gays, I think they are dirty (commentary on the video of Broer.)

As made clear by these examples, producing coming out videos demands an emotional investment of the narrator; an analysis of the comments shows that coming out stories on YouTube are not only received positively, but often harshly judged and rejected.

How the Popularity of Coming Out on YouTube "Functions"

The YouTube platform is a mediator; it has a strategy to push the popularity of certain videos through quantifying the video's views and the times it was liked. When YouTube realized how coming out stories are a popular genre worldwide on the platform, YouTube celebrated coming out stories when the U.S. Supreme Court recognized the constitutional right for all couples to marry. YouTube made a compilation of coming out videos and put them in the "spotlight", launching the hashtag #ProudToLove, which generated a lot of views (YouTube, 2015). Looking at our included cases and the number of views (shown in table one), it can be seen that they are somewhat high, taking into account the Dutch language in which they are produced. While *Luka Peeters* is an exception, the other coming out videos are produced by regular vloggers of whom the coming out video was one of the most popular on the channel, which was the case for *Broer., EricosVlogs* and *Hjalmar*. As argued by Cohler and Hammack, coming out stories are often 'hyperrecognized' because of their 'perceived deviance' (Cohler & Hammack 2007, p. 56). Sometimes, YouTube coming out stories are not only hyperrecog-

nized by 'ordinary' people watching on YouTube, but also followed with a special attention by other mass media. An awareness of the political economy of current media cultures should make it clear that platforms such as YouTube are not separate from the mass media industry and culture, but that both are inextricably intertwined. People's participation in social media and their stories are increasingly becoming promoted, reproduced, and circulated as mass media commodities. In current media culture, there exists a complex convergence between users and producers, amateurs and professionals, media makers and consumers (van Dijck 2013a, p. 128).

Luka Peeters' coming out video became widely recirculated as a mass media commodity. Many Belgian newspapers reported on *Luka Peeters'* coming out video, as shown by the following examples of Belgian newspaper headlines shortly after *Luka Peeters* uploaded his coming out:

> Luka: from fear to fame thanks to YouTube (Krant van West-Vlaanderen)
>
> Luka overwhelmed with praise for coming out video (Het Nieuwsblad)
>
> New trend: out of the closet by making a video (Het Laatste Nieuws)
>
> "One click and all my problems disappeared" (Het Laatste Nieuws)

Because of the significant attention in the national press, *Luka Peeters*'s video became a media spectacle quickly generating over 150.000 YouTube views, reproduced in mass media and shared on numerous social media. This is rather remarkable, as *Luka Peeters* had not uploaded any other video before, he was not a popular vlogger as some of the others were. As argued by Douglas Kellner, (2003), media spectacles centralize a large amount of media power. The political economy of social media "deploys spectacle to promote, reproduce, and circulate commodities" (Kellner, 2003, p. 1) from which mass media, including popular newspapers, are also benefitting.

While there is no particular powerful "center" to the media—no particular corporation, audience, or individual is controlling which coming out video will be made or become 'popular', it is clear that media and its institutions as a whole hold a massive amount of symbolic power; often that power is naturalized in cultures and societies, something which digital and participatory media have made even more complex (Couldry, 2012). Participatory media such as YouTube constructed themselves as "natural" access points to social space wherein queer youths are able to come out. Moreover, it is seen as giving us access to the social reality of queer teens, which is, as we contend, a powerful *myth* that has become naturalized with regard to the way that the media and mediated coming out stories "function." This mythical construction is powerful, as it normalizes the way coming out stories, as previously mentioned, are deeply paradoxical in everyday life (Weeks, 2007). Moreover, it normalizes the reliance of coming out stories on heteronormative culture. This myth is primarily based on a functionalist understanding of the workings of the media (Couldry, 2003)—as if the media were an intermediator where people could participate in a safe space as their "true" selves. In the case of *Luka Peeters*, it is illustrated how media spaces hold particular symbolic power of which there is no control. Several comments on the video of Luka Peeters blamed him for seeking the attention of the media: "I respect you for being gay, but not for the fact that you are demanding so much attention!". Others were harsher, saying things such as "you sick

attention whore". *Luka Peeters* himself responded himself in one of the comments, saying he was not in control of the video becoming so popular in the Belgian press:

> I did not ask for all the attention. When you would have looked at my video than you can see I'm talking to people I actually know, I did not expect to get more than 100 views. So please stop this bullshit. I think I have been able to help many other people with this, so that is what counts.

Recent research on YouTube coming out stories has not deconstructed the myth of how coming out stories "function," but rather has reinforced the naturalized status of the media and their reliance on symbolic power. In his work, Wuest (2014) argues that coming out videos on YouTube produce empowered sexual subjectivities through acculturation and visibility, whereas Cover and Prosser's assertion that queer identities are stabilized on YouTube; yet both see this medium as no more than a meaningless platform on which gender and sexual ideologies are either resisted or incorporated (Abercrombie & Longhurst, 1998). The arguments of Wuest (2014) with regard to the function of YouTube as a platform for the acculturation or visibility of queer youth is problematic precisely because it reproduces the myth *as if* the media were a natural way to become "visible" and "real," and as if the media provided a space to become "acculturated" as a young queer person. Rather, we should ask different questions: How do coming out stories become visible on YouTube? How are media platforms such as YouTube constructed as natural spaces for the acculturation of queer youth culture?

Discussing the Politics of Coming Out Stories on YouTube

The politics of YouTube coming out stories should be considered in relation to the workings of media culture, which would allow for an understanding of how the media shapes and regulates the meanings of coming out stories in queer youth culture. We contend that coming out stories, as a popular media practice, are related to two recent developments in Western culture. The first development involves the specific way in which media have participated in the production of culture in the last two decades. The second evolution is related to the transformation of intimate sexualities that have become endless public dialogues instead of being exclusively private (Plummer, 1995; 2003). Graeme Turner (2010) has referred to these developments in media and culture as "demotic," referring to the "increasing number of ordinary people that appear in the media" (2010, p. 1). The increased participation of "ordinary" people in the media, such as for emotional self-disclosures in talk shows like *Oprah*, but also found in the popular genre of reality TV, have shown that media spectacles are immensely popular. In the current culture, becoming a celebrity is seen as relatively easy as the barrier to large audiences has been lowered, and can be achieved by participating in a game show or launching an entertaining YouTube channel (e.g., the "YouTube celebrity" has become a well-known concept). Turner relates these new forms of media to the increasing commercial challenges for media industries, but also to a crisis of credibility, authority, and what is seen as "real" in the media (2010, p. 2). For example, using "ordinary" people as witnesses in news reports, or granting people access to the media to tell their stories on a talk show, constructs the media as a more credible source of social reality. Recently, digital media culture has constructed, under the form of so-called "social media," the ultimate access point to what is

"real." Social media promises a "live" connection with our families and friends through the use of their platforms (Couldry, 2011).

In tandem with these developments in media culture, we observe a second development: A plethora of sexual stories and images are currently widespread in cultures and societies. Particularly in the media; whether through the consumption of mass media representations, through the creation of self-representations on social networking sites, or through communications with their lovers on (semi-) public digital media platforms (Plummer 1995; 2003; Pascoe, 2011). These endless productions of intimate stories on different media platforms may intervene in how to make sense of cultural identities, such as those of queer youth; these endless productions shape the way "queer" becomes "real." Numerous representations in mass or digital media have the power to authenticate queerness (Gray, 2009).

Both the demotic turn in media and the transformation of intimacies and sexualities in Western cultures have legitimized media as a stage for coming out stories. Whether through reality TV shows, such as *Uit De Kast,* which allow us to follow the "live" and "real" coming out stories of a young gay boy or girl to friends and family, or whether on digital platforms, such as YouTube, wherein we can see people participating in the mediation of their coming out stories, "people are willing to reveal significant and often painful aspects of their lives to large audiences. Meanwhile, media institutions persist and claim legitimacy for their power, based in media's underlying claim to stand in for the social" (Couldry, 2012, p. 72). An apparent question is then: why are people willing to reveal those significant and often painful aspects of their lives?

Behind coming out stories in the media, there seems to be an underlying value; when symbolic forms become valuable, they create symbolic capital, which involves certain distinctions and hierarchies connected to cultural capital (knowledge), but also to economic capital (Bourdieu, 1977; 1984). We could say that through participation in certain media forms, coming out stories give shape to different media-related practices that have a value that is associated with the media. For example, this value could be that queer youth receive enormous support for sharing their "brave" coming out story, which leads to a higher status and reputation within the online economy of YouTube. The media—in this case, YouTube—are essential tools through which this value can be attained through the construction of the myth as if it were the natural access point to queer youths' coming out stories.

The Value of Coming Out on YouTube

The importance of deconstructing the myth of how coming out on YouTube functions becomes clear when the coming out stories we have discussed are considered in relation to the way they generate value within culture and society; understanding their value exposes their relatedness to sexual hierarchies. The use of social media to mediate coming out stories fits within what José van Dijck has described as a wider "culture of connectivity" augmented by the marketing of social media platforms and companies. These platforms have made self-promotion and the branding of the self increasingly valuable in current cultures, and in youth culture specifically; according to van Dijck:

> Promoting and branding the self has also become a normalized, accepted phenomenon in ordinary people's lives. Following the examples of celebrities' self-promotion, many users (especially young

> adults and teenagers) shape their online identities in order to gain popularity and hopefully reach a comfortable level of recognition and connectedness. (van Dijck, 2013b, p. 203)

As coming out stories are popular stories, they maximize the data traffic between people on social media platforms such as YouTube. Both connectivity and storytelling are principles by which social media platforms stir their economic and symbolic power. Coming out stories have value for social media platforms, but also for the individuals who share these stories. As shown in the case studies, the coming out videos were very popular contributions to the vloggers' YouTube channels. A coming out video on YouTube adds value to a coming out story through its extensive visibility and social interactions through likes and comments. In turn, this media visibility can lead to symbolic capital; specifically, the media visibility gained by posting a coming out story on YouTube engenders a specific form of celebrity capital that is intertwined with being visible in the media (Driessens, 2013). *Furtjuh* is one of the examples of YouTube vloggers that has turned his YouTube channel into a carefully styled popular brand. *Furtjuh* is considered as one of the most popular vloggers of the Netherlands and uses many different tactics to generate as much visibility and social traffic on his channel as possible; when *Luka Peeters'* video became popular, he made use of this visibility and started uploading more videos on his channel. Some other international YouTube vloggers take it one step further by using the specific advantage of liveness to add value to their videos. YouTube coming out videos that are internationally the most popular have titles such as "coming out live" or "coming out live to parents"; these titles make coming out stories feel more real and authentic, but they also make coming out videos more spectacular.

Mediated coming out videos take on a hierarchical status as they use particular media categories (such as taking advantage of the "live" element) to become popular, which may provide the storyteller with celebrity capital and connected symbolic capital. Indeed, these videos can provide vloggers with strong online reputations and large audiences. Two stories in Belgian newspapers about YouTube videos in which gay twins come out live to their parents gained significant attention. In one example, an American twin secretly recorded their coming out to their parents (HLN, 2014b), while the other set of gay twins recorded coming out live to their father in a telephone conversation (HLN, 2015). The play with media categories such as blending liveness with dramatization and spectacularization—e.g., the drama of the parents reacting to their twin sons announcing that they are gay at the same time—created an enormous international buzz (travelling far beyond the US context) and popularity for the YouTube channels of both twins. Not only do we need to be aware of the commercial context of these coming out stories, but also of social media culture's obsession with status and self-promotion and what Katherine Sender describes as "emotional labour" (2012). The emotional labor of coming out on YouTube refers to the effort of queer youths to transform a shameful identity into one of pride in order to gain value from a coming out story. This could be seen as a form of immaterial labor that demands an emotional investment. As we have shown in the discussed cases, the narrators were often very nervous to share their coming out stories, while others started crying when talking about the pain and suffering they went through. These queer youths not only have to deal with members of the audience that reject the coming out story, but they must also publicly deal with painful aspects of queer trauma, which was especially the case for *Furtjuh*. This emotional investment is necessary to acquire

dramatic entertainment and spectacle—and thus value. Moreover, this particular investment is linked with the construction of a coherent and recognizable identity and community that is intelligible by a wide audience.

The way that coming out stories have become popular media practices on YouTube should make us question the notion that these videos are simply sharing experiences and providing support within queer communities. We do not argue that all coming out videos are carefully constructed spectacles made by the narrators to acquire symbolic capital; but they do all operate within the logic of social media culture. The practice of publicly "sharing" a coming out experience to publicly support these coming out videos not only provides economic currency for social media companies like YouTube (see our example on #ProudToLove), but even more symbolic, as social media companies construct themselves as the central hub to queer youth sociality at its most vulnerable and defining moment.

Conclusion

While exploring the conjunctions between queer youth culture and contemporary media culture with a critical analysis of the popular media practice of coming out, we deconstructed how coming out on YouTube functions. Thereby, we argued how the media naturalizes the paradox of coming out stories, in that the symbolic power of participatory media such as YouTube normalizes the reliance of these stories' meanings on a heteronormative culture (Weeks, 2007). Even more so, this so-called participatory media have constructed themselves as "natural" access points for young queer teens' socialities, while the workings of social media, which rely mostly on status and self-promotion, are not questioned. By introducing the idea that coming out stories are extending beyond YouTube to be turned into mass media spectacles, we should be aware that popular coming out stories are being promoted, reproduced, and circulated as commodities (Kellner, 2003). This is demonstrated by the visibility of coming out stories on YouTube, as well as by the utilization of dramatization and a "live" element and by the appropriation of coming out stories by commercial reality TV shows such as *Uit De Kast*. Behind coming out stories, there seems to be an underlying value through the acquisition of symbolic capital (Bourdieu, 1984), such as the achievement of status as a celebrity (Driessens, 2013).

Coming out stories as popular media practices in queer youth culture raises some moral questions and the need for reflection on media ethics. These moral questions are—in a broad sense—about how to deal with the lives of queer youth that are emerging in newly pluralized mediated spheres such as social media (Plummer, 2003). Such moral questions always need to be situated in a political context, and more specifically, the politics of sexuality. Social media can offer a space for a democratic voicing of difference (Thumim, 2012) and can, therefore, be relevant for queer youth to come out of invisibility and deal with queer trauma. However, social media logic, such as self-branding, status, and its symbolic power, creates new conflict for the intimate lives of queer youth. For example, the rejection of a coming out video of a queer teen (e.g., homophobic comments responding to the video) could generate a positive democratic conflict; it is possible for the creator of the video and other commenters to rebuke and question these homophobic rejections; however, as previously argued, this could be at the emotional cost of the queer youths involved (Sender, 2012).

Asking the question than if it would not be better for queer youth not to share coming-out stories on YouTube, is asking the wrong question. The ethical question here is how to become different from YouTube (Kember & Zylinska, 2012, p. 172). With becoming different from YouTube, we do not mean using another technology or platform, as YouTube can offer some excellent opportunities. What we do mean is becoming different from popular media cultures that attain an economic or symbolic value to queer youths most vulnerable and defining moment.

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